The Gulf States are generally pro-American, pro-Saudi, and anti-Iranian. An Israeli-Palestinian agreement in the context of a regional arrangement based on the Saudi Initiative satisfies all of these interests. Qatar is an exception that aligned itself with Iran when it realized that it could not necessarily rely on the United States.

The Palestinians

Since the Palestinian National Council's 1988 decision to move forward to resolve the conflict peacefully, the Palestinians have found themselves trapped, making progress difficult and even impossible. They feel a commitment to the Arab refugees and their descendants and are unwilling to give up the "right of return," and on top of this the Arab world expects them to be the guardians of the holy places in Jerusalem. Israel, for its part, does not make it easy for them and raises suspicions (some of them justified) among them that it wants to take over additional areas in the West Bank and change the status quo on the Temple Mount.

An agreement that has the seal of approval of the moderate Arab world, leaving the extremist groups aside, under the patronage of the American superpower, and that will ensure generous and long-term financial aid from Saudi Arabia, is the best and perhaps the only escape from this trap. And if the endorsement of the proposed agreement is in the hands of the participating Arab states, the Palestinians will not be able to refuse it.

Israel

Realistic Israelis—who represent the overwhelming majority both of the Israeli leadership across the political spectrum and of the Israeli population—understand that if and when a solution to the conflict with the Palestinians is achieved, it will be based on a combination of the parameters proposed by Ehud Barak to the Palestinians at Camp David II, the Clinton Parameters, President George W. Bush's "Roadmap," and the (unsigned) agreement between Ehud Olmert and Abu Mazen, all of which are basically variants of the same solution. The Saudi Initiative is close to these parameters. If Israel really wants to resolve the conflict—and I believe it does—it will be willing to adopt the Saudi Initiative as an effective tool for